

Environmental politics and institutions (SK2221) – Course report 2025

15 Higher education credits

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Course content summary

In terms of organization, the course consists of lectures, seminars, individual tutorials, and written assignments. All seminars are mandatory. Like previous years, the course “Environmental politics and institutions” (EPI, SK2221) consists of two major blocks. The first block consists of four themes. All the themes consist of a lecture and a seminar, with a written seminar assignment hand-in. In the second block, the main outcome is that students write a final course paper, with supervision from course teachers. The papers are to be presented at the final seminar, which is the concluding course activity.

In addition, the course starts off with lectures on the theme on 1) the genesis of environmental problems and 2) the history of environmental politics that are offered via recorded lectures, made available to the students via Canvas. This element is there to avoid overlap with the course “Environmental Problems within Social Science: From Tragedy of the Commons to Planetary Boundaries” (SK2223), which many students take prior to the EPI course.

Students in number and grades

The number of registered students was 28. 13 students acquired the grade pass (G) and 12 pass with distinction (VG). 3 students did not finish the course. The ratio between pass and pass with distinction was surprisingly high, but similar to the previous year: In 2024, the share with VG was about 40 percent – it is now about 43 %. Both these years’ numbers of pass with distinction are much higher than in 2023 (20%) and in 2022 and 2021 (about 30 %).

Course evaluation

Assessment of the course

Students' course evaluations consisted of an anonymous digital course evaluation, which followed the final seminar (and very much encouraged to conduct). In total, 9 students completed the course evaluation, corresponding to only some 31% of the students enrolled in the course. With an average reversed score of 4.3, the students that completed this survey were very positive about the 2025 spring term version of the course. The overall assessment is higher than the prior versions of the course, and as positive as in 2022, which was given the highest average before this year's course.

The score for the lectures and the seminars was 4.2 and 4.3. These scores are higher than the last two years. The average scores for the teachers (4.7) and the literature (4.3) are also higher compared to the two years before.

Table 1. Overall assessment of the course and the course content

	Mean score 2024 (n)	Mean score 2024 (n)	Mean score 2023 (n)	Mean score 2022 (n)	Mean score 2021 (n)
Overall, how would you assess the course?	4.3 (9)	3.6 (16)	3.1 (14)	4.3 (11)	4.2 (9)
Overall, how would you assess the lectures?	4.2 (9)	3.9 (16)	3.8 (14)	4.5 (11)	4.2 (9)
Overall, how would you assess the literature?	4.3 (9)	3.9 (16)	3.5 (14)	4.2 (11)	4.7 (9)
Overall, how would you assess the seminars?	4.7 (9)	4.2 (16)	3.2 (14)	4.5 (11)	3.6 (9)
Overall, how would you assess the teachers?	4.7 (9)	4.2 (16)	3.8 (14)	4.7 (11)	4.3 (9)

Comment: Respondents were asked to respond on a scale from 5 to 1. 5= Very good, 4= rather good, 3= Neither good nor bad, 2= rather bad and 1= very bad.

When it comes to examinations, the average score for the course theme assignment and the course paper tutorials was 4.4 and 4.1, which is also higher than the previous year. The score for the course paper was 4.1, which can be compared to 3.7 in the 2024 edition of the course. The score for the assessment of the organization was 4.3, which is also higher than in 2023.

Themes raised in the written comments from students:

More lectures

As in previous years, selected feedback point to a demand for more lectures (two students mention this in open-ended answers). One comment reads: “Lectures and teachers were amazing, but lectures were too few...”

Level of difficulty

All nine students completing the survey indicated that the level of demands from the course was “OK” (3), on a scale of possible responses that ranged from (1) Much too demanding (2) Somewhat too demanding, (3) OK, (4) Not that demanding and (5) Not at all demanding.

Still, one or two students did mention in open-ended answers that they felt they were short on time when writing the final paper.

More constructive feedback

Students highlighted in the evaluation that they would prefer even more constructive comments when faced with difficulties in their final paper.

Suggested changes for the next round of the course

Because of the overall very positive feedback, this do not suggest the need of large changes to address any big problems. The teacher team will coordinate to give even more constructive comments.

Looking forward – and given new information from department leadership about pending cuts in the course budget – Aksel has decided to mainly save these hours by reducing the course coordinating hours. Aksel will take over as course coordinator and will do so using fewer hours. He will also slightly trim down the time for individual supervision. Because the feedback over the years have been to have even more lectures, cutting in this end would not go in line with that sentiment.